

1 Introduction

Language attitude research is crucial for understanding how linguistic differences shape perceptions. Since English is a lingua franca spoken in various accents, examining attitudes towards its non-native varieties is essential. Especially British native speakers' perceptions influence accent legitimacy in countries where British English is considered normative. Among those, Austria appears unique since attitudes towards its accent remain underexplored. This study, inspired by my experience as an Austrian in Scotland, focuses on the attitudes of UK-based English native speakers towards Austrian-accented English.

2 Literature review

2.1 Language attitudes

Language attitudes indicate the evaluations allocated to speakers of distinct varieties. Particularly, accents are used to distinguish speakers' nationality, ethnicity, or socioeconomic class (Eisenchlas & Tsurutani, 2011). Non-standard accents often evoke stereotypes linked to social categories, entailing negative judgements, especially among dominant speech communities (Lambert et al., 1960). This might entail biased treatment or reduced performance expectations (Riches & Foddy, 1989) and impact employment, education, or housing opportunities (Eisenchlas & Tsurutani, 2011). Thus, language attitudes incorporate social categorisation since accents are perceived as indicators for social identities.

Evaluations of language attitudes mainly encompass the dimensions of status (e.g. intelligence) and solidarity (e.g. friendliness). Typically, foreign-accented speakers receive unfavourable ratings regarding both, owing to stereotyping and processing fluency. The more the speakers' accents differ from the listeners', the harder the speakers' speech is to process

and the more negatively it is evaluated (Dragojevic & Goatley-Soan, 2022). Ratings of status and solidarity features are therefore linked to social categorisation and processing fluency.

2.2 Matched-guise technique

Techniques for studying language attitudes are separated into direct and indirect methods. While direct strategies ask informants about their attitudes to varieties, indirect ones expose them to recordings (Ryan et al., 1982). As direct methods might arouse answers targeted at social desirability, indirect methods, e.g. the matched-guise technique, are preferred.

The matched-guise technique is typically used to examine native speakers' attitudes towards foreign accents. It assumes that individuals utilise cues from their interlocutors' speech, e.g. accents, to access non-linguistic information (Dalton-Puffer et al., 1997). Participants hear recordings of multilingual speakers employing English and rate them on scales (Eisenchlas & Tsurutani, 2011).

By disguising the object of study, providing audio stimuli of foreign-accented speakers, and evaluating features on Likert scales, my experiment implements the matched-guise technique efficiently.

2.3 Previous language attitude studies

Following Lambert et al.'s (1960) groundbreaking study, language attitudes towards non-mainstream English accents have been extensively researched. Dragojevic and Goatley-Soan (2022) found Americans rated non-Anglo foreign accents lower than Standard American English on status and solidarity traits. Seggie et al. (1982) showed RP speakers were ranked higher than Cockney speakers regarding employment. Purnell et al. (1999) highlighted discrimination in housing markets, with Standard American English preferred over Chicano English. These studies showcase that non-mainstream English accents are judged

unfavourably, entailing tangible disadvantages for speakers, e.g. reduced employment opportunities. Understanding language attitudes is essential to combat these biases.

German-accented English has also been addressed. Dragojevic and Goatley-Soan (2022) found German-accented English rated higher than Eastern varieties but lower than Standard American English. Ball (1983) investigated students' perceptions of different European accents, connecting German with attractiveness and competence. In comparison, Austrian accents have received little attention. Despite phonetic differences (Moosmüller et al., 2015), Austrian and German varieties are usually grouped together. However, studying Austrian-accented English separately yields interesting results. For example, Dalton-Puffer et al. (1997) revealed students rated Austrian-accented English less favourably than native accents. Overall, attitudes towards Austrian accents remain largely unexamined, underscoring the need for further research.

3 Experimental design

3.1 Research questions

Hence, this study investigates the following research questions:

(1) *What are the language attitudes of UK-based native speakers of English towards Austrian-accented English?*

(1.1) *Do gender differences among Austrian-accented speakers of English influence these attitudes, and if so, how?*

By focusing on the Austrian variety of English, the experiment contributes to an understanding of language attitudes and stereotypes associated with less-researched non-native accents. Exploring gendered perceptions reflects ongoing sociolinguistic discussions about

language-gender interrelationships and gender-linked language effects (Lindvall-Östling et al., 2020; Mulac et al., 2013).

3.2 Procedure

This experiment would be conducted on MTurk with 150 participants (>100 usable sets after data cleaning), compensated \$4 for 10-15 minutes, complying with the national living wage (UK Government, 2024). Following Pavlick et al.'s (2014) suggestions ensuring eligibility, informants would be restricted to UK-locations and native speakers of English.

The experiment includes a language attitude survey utilising the matched-guise technique. First, participants read a description of the survey, including prerequisites, and give consent. The purpose is not disclosed, avoiding social-desirability bias. According to the 'cover', participants evaluate someone's suitability for the job 'weather forecaster'. Second, participants must confirm they are UK-based native English speakers, excluding non-qualifiers. Language proficiency is checked through a cloze. Next, the screen displays the procedure and stimuli script, followed by a soundcheck and instructions for evaluation. Reading the script familiarises participants with the recordings' content, ensuring they focus on voice. Afterwards, participants listen to a female speaker and rate 15 'The person'-statements and 4 'I'-statements, using 5-point Likert scales. Audio can be replayed using a miniplayer. Then, participants name the speaker's first language and nationality. While this is not directly relevant, it reveals how participants interpret identity from linguistic cues, highlighting stereotypes. Subsequently, the procedure repeats with a male speaker. Finally, participants complete demographic surveys before receiving completion codes.

Data is saved to CSV-files trial by trial, enhancing reliability and capturing essential information. Evaluation data (*fe_data_participant_ID*), i.e. the focus of analysis, and survey data (*fe_survey_participant_ID*) are stored in separate files, simplifying information

management and distinguishing task-related performance data from demographic details. To connect both, participants receive random, unique participant-IDs, stated in the file names. For analysis, attributes could be categorised into three dimensions: competence (e.g. intelligence/ambition/successfulness/educatedness/industriousness), personal integrity (e.g. reliability/honestness/trustworthiness/open-mindedness/politeness), and social attractiveness (e.g. outgoingness/sociableness/friendliness/likeability/confidence). Tools like Excel could visualise data (Figure 1).

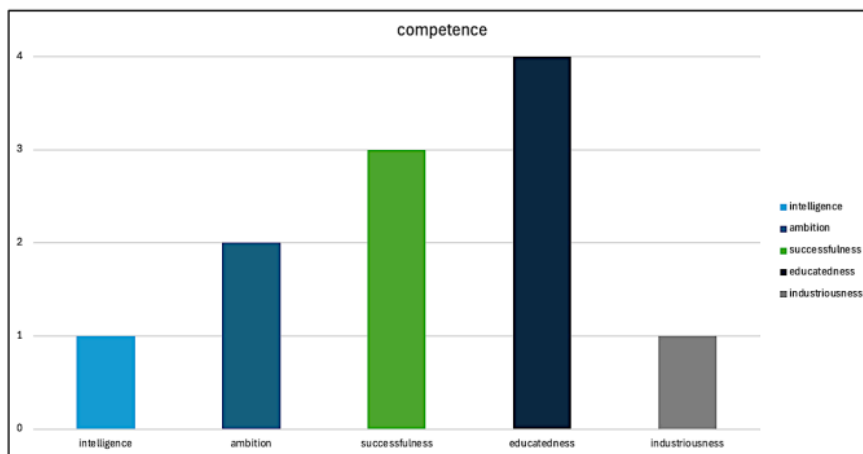


Figure 1. Visualisation example of the ‘competence’ dimension (0=‘Strongly disagree’; 4=‘Strongly agree’)

3.3 Design decisions

Trial responses are *required* to ensure reliable data and prevent participants from skipping questions. Similarly, participants cannot click *Continue*-buttons while stimuli are playing (*response_allowed_while_playing* = false), forcing them to listen to the recordings and maintain a controlled, unrushed pace.

The soundcheck serves a double function. First, participants verify their setup using a 1-minute copyright-free piano song with a broad audio spectrum, allowing time to adjust speakers/headphones. If needed, the sound file can be replayed manually, using HTML-audio. Second, it acts as an attention check by requiring a specific keyboard response (‘y’). Utilising

audio-keyboard-response instead of simple button responses ensures participants follow instructions precisely.

To restrict participation to UK-based native English speakers, a yes/no-question (*survey-multi-choice*) is embedded into a conditional trial. If participants select ‘No’, the timeline runs a screen explaining the reason for exclusion instead of terminating the experiment immediately, enabling transparency while ending participation. To create screens without *Continue*-options, I utilised *html-button-response* and left ‘choices’ empty. Upon clicking ‘Yes’, a proficiency check (*cloze*) appears, following Pavlick et al.’s (2014) suggestion to validate language abilities with narrative clozes. The text targets college-level readers, indicating appropriate difficulty (Oller et al., 1971). The first lines remain intact; 15 blanks are given. Answers are compared against solutions (cf. Appendix). If discrepancies arise, *mistake_fn* triggers alerts prompting participants to retry. Adequately skilled participants should be able to complete the task effortlessly, while unqualified ones are deterred.

Voices are intentionally disembodied, i.e. no accompanying pictures/information, to avoid skewed ratings. Similarly, indirect elicitation methods prevent bias, with chosen adjectives representing solidarity and status features (cf. Dragojevic & Goatley-Soan, 2022). The adjective list (‘The person’-statements) is followed by abstract summary statements (‘I’-statements), accessing more cognitive attitude aspects.

For scoring, I chose *survey-likert* over *audio-slider-response*. While convenient and intuitive, audio-slider responses require separate screens per statement, making evaluating 19 attributes cumbersome. Previously, I also considered button responses but found them unwieldy and impractical. Likert scales allow multiple items per page with five-point ranges (‘Strongly disagree’-‘Strongly agree’), expressing subtle sentiments. Randomising the order of

statements reduces primacy/recency effects and response patterns, encouraging more thoughtful answers.

A minor coding challenge involved enabling participants to replay recordings on-demand while evaluating, refreshing their memory or compensating for distractions during initial listenings. Since *survey-likert* lacks built-in audio functionality, I added an HTML `<audio>` element in the preamble, providing an audio file and playback controls (play/pause/volume). Unlike *audio-button-response*, HTML-audio does not automatically autoplay, allowing participants to relisten on-demand.

For the demographic survey, I used *survey-html-form* since its layout appears cleaner (e.g. scroller, radio buttons) and more accessible than multiple *html-button* responses, for instance. Reviewing ‘age’, ‘gender’, ‘stays abroad’, and ‘friend groups’ helps contextualise responses. Especially experiences abroad and diverse friendships are relevant for openness to linguistic diversity. Moreover, a concealed native-speaker verification identifies impostors who lied earlier.

3.4 Audio stimuli

The audio, including a female and a male voice, was recorded on 18./19.11.2024, using the ‘Voice Memos’ app on an iPhone 11 (female) and an iPhone 13 Pro (male), lacking professional equipment. Real experiments would utilise soundproof booths and high-quality microphones, with recordings normalised to 70 dB.

Speakers are 22-year-old university students from Upper Austria residing in Vienna, ensuring comparability in age, education, and residence. While both possess recognisable Austrian accents, the woman has a CEFR level of C1, studying English at university, while the man, using English occasionally, has B2. Ideally, speakers of identical proficiency would be used.

Both read the same 99-word passage, taking 33 (male) and 36 seconds (female) to complete.

The text, an authentic weather forecast (BBC, 2024), follows Fasold's (1984) guideline to use neutral, non-controversial material.



3.5 Improvements

Implementing a single reading passage might limit the findings' generalisability. Even with factual material, content can impact speaker ratings. Future research could analyse scorings with various texts/genres and compare evaluative profiles. Moreover, context may shape attitudes towards accents. Instead of focusing on one scenario, e.g. job suitability, multiple social settings could be considered. Reading out texts also lacks authenticity and real-world communication. Perceptions might differ when evaluating e.g. dialogue. Recording Austrian-accented speakers in conversations and having participants evaluate them could provide more realistic insights.

More than two speakers would be beneficial, as two cannot capture the variability within each gender potentially affecting perceptions, e.g. pitch. Using at least two men and women (cf. Dragojevic & Goatley-Soan, 2022) would provide a more balanced representation, although it could introduce uncontrolled variation. Selecting comparable speakers (e.g. accent/voice quality/reading rate/age) is crucial.

Another weakness is relying on self-reported first language and residence, possibly entailing unreliable responses and reduced data validity. Self-reports are subjective and lack independent verification. While crowdsourcing websites offer IP-location and language filters, participants ultimately control their data and may provide false information to qualify. Even with screening measures, researchers cannot confirm whether participants belong to target groups. Non-native speakers with suitable English skills could still pass verification questions and proficiency checks. Elaborate background questions could have been added, but these would not mitigate

the possibility of dishonest responses. Thus, without external verification (e.g. documents), I must rely on participants' honesty.

Selecting an appropriate level for the cloze was challenging. It should neither be too easy, allowing lower-proficiency speakers to pass, nor too difficult, deterring eligible participants. Particularly as a non-native speaker, assessing this was challenging. I used a cloze from Oller et al. (1971), originally tested with native speakers, but adapted overly difficult blanks, e.g. 'stamina'. Developing and pilot-testing multiple versions with native speakers could help refine the difficulty.

Another limitation in attitude studies are subjective descriptors. Participants might interpret terms, e.g. 'friendly', differently, entailing inconsistent responses. Researchers could include open-ended questions, allowing participants to express attitudes freely, and clarify descriptors through pilot-testing or precise definitions. Furthermore, selecting only 19 descriptors may oversimplify constructs or fail to capture the range of perceptions. Expanding the list could address this issue.

4 Impact

Discovering language attitudes towards Austrian-accented English has practical significance since awareness helps reduce biases against foreign-accented speakers in professional, educational, and social contexts. As an aspiring Austrian teacher of English, grasping the prejudice students face abroad due to their accents seems crucial to prepare them adequately.

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Appendix

Narrative cloze (Oller et al., 1971, p. 195)

Confusion exists concerning the real purposes, aims, and goals of a college. What are these? What should a college be? Some believe that the chief function **of** even a liberal arts college is **a** vocational one. I feel that the **vocational** function of a college, while important, **is** nonetheless secondary. Others profess that the chief purpose **of** a college is to produce paragons of moral, mental, **and** spiritual stamina. If they mean **that** the college **should** include students **with** the highest moral, ethical, and religious **standards**, I am **willing** to accept the thesis. I **believe** in attention to both social amenities **and** regulations, but I prefer to see our **colleges** get down **to** more moral and ethical considerations.

GRADEMARK REPORT

FINAL GRADE

82/100

GENERAL COMMENTS

This report is an excellent piece of work. The overall structure is easy to follow.

The literature review is very clear and comprehensive, effectively identifying the research gap in the existing literature and presenting a strong motivation for the study.

I was confused at first by the mismatch between the broad focus on language attitudes in your literature review and research questions, and the specific focus on job-related stimuli in your experiment. While you discussed the generalisability of the results and suggested including more scenarios in the experiment, it would be helpful to explain the significance of using specific situations in your current study and how they contribute to the broader research context.

The experiment runs smoothly and is nicely presented. The instructions are clear, concise, and easy for participants to follow.

Discussions regarding potential improvements are thoughtful.

Strengths: excellent literature review, strong motivation, nicely designed experiment.

weaknesses: No major weaknesses. Just a couple of minor issues, such as the unclear source of the Likert scale statements.

PAGE 1

PAGE 2



Comment 1

The literature review is very clear and comprehensive.

PAGE 3

PAGE 4

PAGE 5



Comment 2

You might want to include where this script come from.



Comment 3

It might be better if you could explicitly clarify whether you created those statements yourself or adapted them from existing paper(s).



Comment 4

Your design decisions are very reasonable!

Actually, you do not need to mention the specific parameters and the names of plugins used in the experiment. Just say the task is designed as it is, which keeps the explanation straightforward and concise.



Comment 5

Now I see the source! Introducing stimuli earlier in the report, preferably before the procedure section, would make it clearer for readers from the beginning.

